Plan 2 · Offbeat Shimla + Manali

Same two hubs, but you stay in the quiet valleys: Mashobra, Shali Tibba, Narkanda–Hatu, Thanedar–Kotgarh, Jibhi, Shoja, Jalori/Serolsar, Tirthan, Naggar, Sethan.
24 Dec 2026 – 3 Jan 2027

At a glance

Route	Hyderabad → Delhi → Shimla (evening walk) → Mashobra 1N → Narkanda 2N → Jibhi 2N → Tirthan 1N → Sethan 1N (NYE) → Manali → Delhi → Hyderabad
Why offbeat	You sleep in villages, not Mall Road hotels. NYE is spent in Sethan (snow village) instead of jammed Old Manali. You still see Shimla's Ridge, and Manali's Hadimba/Vashisht on the last day.
Snow chances	High: Hatu, Jalori/Serolsar, Sethan. Medium: Narkanda, Shoja. Low–medium: Jibhi, Tirthan (snow in some years after mid-Dec)
Crowd level	Low almost everywhere; medium only at Shimla Mall on 25 Dec and Manali on 1 Jan
Difficulty	Easy–moderate. Optional snow hikes: Shali Tibba (3 km), Hatu (if road closed), Serolsar (5 km each way)
Budget (per person)	≈ ₹25.4k shoestring · ≈ ₹31.2k recommended (group of 4). ≈ ₹29k with 6 people sharing a Tempo Traveller
Temperatures	Narkanda −6 to 6 °C · Jibhi −2 to 10 °C · Sethan −10 to 2 °C

The one road to watch: Jalori Pass (3,120 m)

Jalori is the short link from Narkanda to Jibhi (via Luhri–Ani–Jalori–Shoja, ~110 km, 5 h). It usually closes to vehicles after heavy snow from **mid to late December** and reopens in March–April. Travel blogs say the Jalori route is not reliable in December.

Decision on 27 Dec evening (ask your Narkanda host / Ani police): open → go via Jalori (best views). Closed → go Narkanda → Shimla → Sundernagar → Mandi → Aut → Banjar → Jibhi (~260 km, 8–9 h). Jibhi itself is reachable year-round via Aut; only the section above Shoja shuts. You can still hike to Jalori / Serolsar from Shoja in snow.

Getting there and back

Hyderabad → Delhi: trains that work for 24 Dec (early morning first)

Train	Boards in Hyderabad	Reaches	Runs	Classes · approx fare / person	Use on 24 Dec?
22691 Bengaluru–Nizamuddin Rajdhani	Secunderabad **07:00 arr / 07:10 dep** (10-min halt)	H. Nizamuddin ~05:30 next day (~22 h)	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100 · 2A ≈ ₹4,500–5,500 (flexi fare, meals incl.)	Yes. Fastest morning option
12723 Telangana SF Exp	Hyderabad Deccan (Nampally) **06:00** · Secunderabad 06:20/06:25	New Delhi ~07:40–08:00 next day (~25.5 h)	Daily	SL ≈ ₹800 · 3A ≈ ₹2,100 · 2A ≈ ₹3,000	**Yes, best early-morning train**
12285 Secunderabad–Nizamuddin Duronto	Secunderabad **12:50**	H. Nizamuddin ~10:40 next day (~22 h)	**Sun & Thu**	AC only · 3A ≈ ₹3,000–3,700 (meals incl.)	**Yes, 24 Dec is a Thursday**
12721 Dakshin SF Exp	Hyderabad Deccan 23:00	H. Nizamuddin ~03:45 on day 3 (~29 h)	Daily	SL ≈ ₹780 · 3A ≈ ₹2,100	Only as a 23-Dec-night fallback (slow)

12723 major halts, in order (check availability to each): Hyderabad Deccan → Secunderabad → Kazipet → Ramagundam → Mancherial → Sirpur Kagaznagar → Balharshah → Chandrapur → Sevagram → Nagpur → Itarsi → Bhopal → Jhansi → Gwalior →

Agra Cantt → New Delhi (about 18 halts in total, ~1,680 km). Confirmed times: HYB 06:00, SC 06:20/06:25, Kazipet 08:03/08:05, Ramagundam 09:28/09:30. Read the other times off NTES or IRCTC on the day.

Waitlisted? Check every halt this way

Step 1. Direct pairs. On IRCTC (or ConfirmTkt / ixigo, same data), search 24 Dec for HYB→NDLS, SC→NDLS, SC→NZM, HYB→NZM in 3A and SL. Note the status for each train: AVAILABLE / RAC / WL number.

Step 2. Every halt (as you asked). If HYB/SC→Delhi shows WL, search the same train from **HYB** to each later halt: Agra Cantt, Gwalior, Jhansi, Bhopal, Itarsi, Nagpur. Seats are split into quotas by distance, so a shorter ticket (e.g. HYB→Agra) can be AVAILABLE while HYB→Delhi is WL. If Agra/Gwalior is available, book it, ride to Agra (about 4 h before Delhi), then take any Agra→Delhi train, Gatimaan/Vande Bharat or bus (2–3.5 h, ₹300–800).

Step 3. Book from the train's origin. For trains that start outside Hyderabad (22691 Rajdhani from Bengaluru, 22705 Humsafar from Tirupati), search **origin→Delhi** (SBC→NZM, TPTY→NZM/Jammu) and set **Boarding Point = Secunderabad**. You pay the full-route fare, but the origin's general quota is often open when the Secunderabad quota is full.

Step 4. Board further up the line. Check the same trains from Kazipet / Ramagundam (table above). You can book HYB→Delhi and board at SC, but you cannot board before the boarding station on your ticket.

Step 5. Split journey. HYB→Nagpur (many trains, short) + Nagpur→Delhi (30+ trains, incl. Rajdhanis from the south). Leave at least 2–3 h for the change.

Step 6. Tatkal on 23 Dec. AC Tatkal opens 10:00 AM, sleeper 11:00 AM. You need an Aadhaar-authenticated IRCTC account (OTP). Log in at 9:55 with saved passenger lists and UPI ready. Premium Tatkal costs more but is easier to get.

Delhi → Hyderabad: trains that get you home by 3 Jan

Train	Leaves	Reaches Hyderabad	Runs	Approx fare (3A)	Fits 'home by 3 Jan'?
12724 Telangana SF Exp	New Delhi **16:00**	Hyderabad Deccan ~17:10 next day	Daily	≈ ₹2,100 (SL ≈ ₹800)	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan evening**
22692 Nizamuddin–Bengaluru Rajdhani	H. Nizamuddin late evening (≈20:30–21:00, verify)	Secunderabad 17:10 arr / 17:25 dep next day	Daily	≈ ₹3,300–4,100	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan 17:10**
12286 Nizamuddin–Secunderabad Duronto	H. Nizamuddin 15:55	Secunderabad ~14:35 next day	Mon & Fri	≈ ₹3,000–3,700	Leave 1 Jan (Fri) → home 2 Jan
12722 Dakshin SF Exp	H. Nizamuddin 22:50	Hyderabad Deccan ~03:50 on day 3	Daily	≈ ₹2,100	Leave 1 Jan night → home 3 Jan 04:00

Hill transfers

Leg	How	Time	Approx cost
Delhi → Shimla	HRTC Volvo, ISBT Kashmere Gate (06:45 / 08:00 if on Rajdhani; 09:25 / 11:55 if on Telangana)	8–9.5 h	₹980–1,100 pp
Shimla → Mashobra	Local taxi (12 km)	40 min	₹600–800 per car
Mashobra → Shali Tibba (Khatnol) → Narkanda	Day taxi	4–5 h with trek	₹3,500–4,000 per car
Narkanda → Jibhi	Taxi via Jalori (if open) or via Mandi–Aut	5 h / 8–9 h	₹6,000–7,000 / ₹8,000–9,500 per car
Jibhi ↔ Shoja ↔ Jalori, Jibhi → Gushaini	Local taxi / HRTC Banjar–Shoja bus (₹30–60)	30–60 min	₹1,500–2,500 per car per day
Gushaini → Aut → Naggar → Sethan	Taxi via Aut tunnel and Kullu	4.5–5 h	₹5,000–5,500 per car
Manali → Delhi	HRTC / private Volvo (16:00–18:00 dep)	12–14 h	₹1,600–2,000 pp

Public-transport option for Jibhi: overnight Volvo Delhi → Aut (from ~₹660, last bus ~23:35), then a local bus to Banjar (~₹40) and Jibhi (~₹20). Useful if you do Jibhi before Narkanda (reverse loop).

Flights from Hyderabad (to save 1–2 days)

Route (non-stop)	Airlines	Flight time	Typical Dec–Jan one-way fare*	Useful for
Hyderabad ↔ Delhi	IndiGo, Air India, Akasa, SpiceJet (many daily)	~2 h 10 m	₹6,000–9,000 (24 Dec / 2 Jan can touch ₹10–12k)	Plans 1, 2, 3, 5
Hyderabad → Chandigarh	IndiGo (≈2 daily)	~2 h 30 m	₹7,000–9,500	Plans 1 & 2 (Shimla is 3–4 h from IXC)

*Snapshot ranges from MakeMyTrip, Goibibo, Skyscanner, HappyFares and ixigo pages seen in Nov 2026, not live quotes. IndiGo cabin bag: 7 kg; check-in 15 kg on most fares. Winter jackets count, so wear the heaviest layers on the plane. Book within the next 1–2 weeks: Christmas/New Year fares on these routes usually climb steadily.

Day-by-day itinerary

Day 1 · Thu 24 Dec · Hyderabad → on the train

• **Best: 07:10 22691 Rajdhani** from Secunderabad → Nizamuddin 05:30 (25 Dec). Gets you on the early Shimla Volvo.

• Else **06:00 12723 Telangana Express** (Hyderabad Deccan) → New Delhi ~07:40.

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 food (Rajdhani includes meals)

Day 2 · Fri 25 Dec · Delhi → Shimla → Mashobra

• Volvo to Shimla. If you arrive by 15:00–16:00, walk the Ridge and Christ Church for Christmas, then taxi to **Mashobra** (12 km, 2,150 m).

• If you arrive late, sleep in Shimla and move to Mashobra in the morning.

Stay: Mashobra homestay / cottage (₹1,800–3,000 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,000 bus + ₹200 taxi share + ₹600 food

Day 3 · Sat 26 Dec · Shali Tibba trek → Narkanda

• **Shali Tibba (2,872 m)**, offbeat: drive to Khatnol village, 3 km uphill trail to the Bhima Kali temple on the summit. 360° view of Shimla hills and the Pir Panjal. 3–4 h return. Snow likely on top late Dec, so spikes help.

• Optional quick stop: **Naldehra** deodar meadow (golf course) near Mashobra.

• Drive on to **Narkanda** via Kufri–Fagu–Theog (~2 h).

Stay: Narkanda homestay / HPTDC Hatu (₹1,800–2,800 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹900 taxi share + ₹700 food

Day 4 · Sun 27 Dec · Hatu Peak · Tani Jubbar · Thanedar–Kotgarh

• Sunrise drive/hike to **Hatu Peak (3,400 m)**: Hatu Mata temple and Bhim's chulha rocks. If snow blocks the road, it's a 7 km snow walk up.

• **Tani Jubbar lake**: quiet forest lake.

• Afternoon: **Thanedar & Kotgarh** (offbeat apple country, 17 km): Samuel Stokes' orchards, the 1843 St Mary's Church at Kotgarh, Sutlej valley views.

• Evening: confirm the Jalori status (box above) and fix tomorrow's taxi.

Stay: Narkanda | **Day spend (per person):** ₹750 taxi share + ₹700 food

Day 5 · Mon 28 Dec · Narkanda → Jibhi

• Route A (Jalori open): Narkanda → Luhri (Sutlej) → Ani → **Jalori Pass** (stop at the dhabas, snow) → Shoja → Jibhi.

• Route B (Jalori closed): via Shimla bypass → Sundernagar → Mandi → Aut tunnel → Banjar → Jibhi. Leave by 07:00.

• Evening: Jibhi village walk and riverside café.

Stay: Jibhi treehouse / riverside homestay (₹1,500–2,500 per room, meals ₹300–400) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,750–2,375 taxi share + ₹700 food

Day 6 · Tue 29 Dec · Jibhi · Chehni Kothi · Shoja · Serolsar

• **Chehni Kothi**: centuries-old ~15-storey stone-and-wood tower temple. 2 km walk up from Bahu/Chehni village.

• **Jibhi waterfall** and the 'Mini Thailand' rock pool on the Pushpabhadra river.

• **Shoja** (2,700 m): viewpoint and waterfall. If Jalori is open, drive up and hike 5 km to **Serolsar lake** (Budhi Nagin temple) through oak forest, with a local guide (₹1,500–2,000 per group). If it's closed, hike from Shoja towards Jalori as far as is safe.

• Cafés in Shoja/Jibhi close early (by ~21:00) in winter.

Stay: Jibhi | **Day spend (per person):** ₹600 taxi share + ₹400 guide share + ₹700 food

Day 7 · Wed 30 Dec · Tirthan valley (Great Himalayan National Park)

- Short move to **Gushaini** (Tirthan valley, ~35 km).
- Walk the river trail to **Bandal** village, see the trout farms at Nagini, and visit the GHNP (UNESCO site) entry/interpretation area. Winter treks inside the park need a permit and guide, so keep it to day walks.
- Evening by the Tirthan river (trout dinner if you eat fish).

Stay: Tirthan riverside homestay (₹1,500–2,500 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹375 taxi share + ₹800 food

Day 8 · Thu 31 Dec · Tirthan → Naggar → Jana → Sethan (quiet NYE in snow)

- Drive via Aut tunnel → Kullu → left bank road to **Naggar Castle** + **Roerich Art Gallery**.
- Lunch at **Jana waterfall** village dhabas.
- Up to **Sethan (2,700 m)** above Prini: snow village with igloo cafés, bonfire NYE away from the Manali crowd.
- Upgrade option: a night in an igloo stay (₹4,500–7,500 pp with meals). Otherwise a homestay, and visit the igloos in the day.

Stay: Sethan homestay (₹2,000–3,000 per room incl. dinner) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,375 taxi share + ₹800 food

Day 9 · Fri 1 Jan · Sethan snow morning → Vashisht → Old Manali → Volvo to Delhi

- Morning snow walk on the Hampta trail head (no crowd, great light).
- Down to Manali: **Hadimba temple**, **Vashisht hot springs**, Old Manali lunch.
- Evening HRTC/private Volvo to Delhi (book ahead; 16:00–18:00 departure).

Stay: Overnight Volvo | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 taxi share + ₹1,800 Volvo + ₹600 food

Day 10 · Sat 2 Jan · Delhi → train home

- Arrive Delhi 06:00–08:00. Day room in Paharganj (shared) or the station waiting lounge.
- **16:00 12724 Telangana Express** (or 22692 Rajdhani from Nizamuddin in the late evening).

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 room share + ₹600 food

Day 11 · Sun 3 Jan · Home

- Hyderabad ~17:10.

Offbeat places in this plan

Place	Altitude	What's special	Snow chance late Dec	Crowd
Mashobra / Naldehra	2,150 m	Apple-orchard ridge and deodar meadows next to Shimla	Low–medium	Low
Shali Tibba	2,872 m	Summit temple trek, best panorama near Shimla	Medium–high	Very low
Narkanda + Hatu Peak	2,708 / 3,400 m	Snow slopes, Hatu Mata temple	High	Low
Thanedar–Kotgarh	~2,000 m	Where Himachal's apples began; 1843 church	Low	Very low
Jalori Pass + Serolsar lake	3,120 m	Snow pass and sacred forest lake	Very high (road may close)	Very low
Jibhi, Chehni Kothi, Shoja	1,900–2,700 m	Wooden villages, tower temple, treehouses	Medium (Shoja higher)	Low
Tirthan / Gushaini / Bandal	1,600 m	Trout river, GHNP edge	Low–medium	Very low
Naggar, Jana waterfall	1,800–2,300 m	Old Kullu capital, village food	Low–medium	Low
Sethan	2,700 m	Igloo village, Hampta trail head	High	Low

Main sights still covered: Shimla Ridge/Christ Church/Mall (Day 2), Kufri (passing through), Hadimba, Vashisht, Old Manali (Day 9).

Bike / scooty rentals

Where	Rates	Notes
Shimla	Scooty ₹500–800 · 150–200 cc ₹900–1,500	Good for Mashobra–Naldehra on a dry day; not for Narkanda in snow
Jibhi / Banjar	Scooty ₹700–1,000 (few shops; ask your homestay)	Useful for Jibhi–Chehni–Shoja on dry roads. Jalori road in snow: no
Manali	Scooty ₹500–800 · RE ₹1,200–2,500	Day 9 only; Sethan road is steep and icy, so take a taxi

Winter gear: what to buy, what to rent, and where

Budget for gear: if you own nothing warm, expect ₹4,000–6,500 one-time purchase (thermals, fleece, gloves, cap, socks, sunglasses) + ₹800–1,500 in rentals on the trip (jacket, suit, boots, spikes). The per-plan budgets include only the **rental** part; the purchases you keep are listed separately.

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Thermal inner set (top + bottom) ×2	Must	₹800–1,200 per set (local ₹400–600)	Not rented (hygiene)	Buy. Merino/poly, not cotton
Fleece / sweater (mid layer)	Must	₹600–1,200	—	Buy
Padded / down jacket (rated −5 to −10 °C)	Must	₹2,500–5,000	Indiahikes rentals ₹55–80/day (ships to you); trek operators ₹100/day; Manali / Gulmarg shops ₹150–300/day	Rent if you'll never use it again. 10 days ≈ ₹600–1,000
One-piece snow suit	At snow points	—	Solang/Palchan, Kufri, Gulmarg, Tsomgo ₹250–500/day (often with gumboots)	Rent on the spot only on snow days
Gumboots / snow boots	At snow points	—	₹100–200/day (Lachung ~₹100; bundled with suit at Solang ₹400–500)	Rent on the spot
Waterproof trekking shoes	Must (Plans 2, 4, 5)	₹2,000–3,500 (Decathlon MH100/MH500)	Trek operators ₹100–150/day	Buy if you'll trek again
Waterproof gloves + woollen inners	Must	₹300–900 + ₹150	—	Buy
Woollen cap / balaclava / neck gaiter	Must	₹200–400 each	—	Buy
Woollen socks (4 pairs)	Must	₹400–600	—	Buy
UV400 sunglasses	Must on snow	₹300–800	—	Snow glare causes snow-blindness
Microspikes + gaiters	Chopta, Hatu, Jalori, Gulmarg walks	₹1,200–1,800	Chopta/Sari/Sankri ₹150–250/day; gaiters ₹100/day	Rent

Rental points on this route

Point	What you can rent	Rate
Narkanda (ski shops / HPTDC)	Ski kit, gumboots, snow suits (when slopes are open)	₹300–500 suit; ski kit ₹700–1,000
Shoja / Jibhi homestays	Gumboots, sometimes microspikes and poles for the Serolsar hike	₹100–250
Sethan (igloo operators)	Snow suits, boots, skis/snowboards	₹300–600
Indiahikes rentals (online)	Padded jacket, trek shoes, microspikes	₹55–150/day

Budget (per person, 4 people)

Item (per person)	Shoestring	Recommended	Notes
Train Hyderabad → Delhi	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A Telangana (Rajdhani 3A adds ≈ ₹1,200)
Train Delhi → Hyderabad	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A Telangana
Delhi → Shimla HRTC Volvo	₹1,000	₹1,000	
Manali → Delhi Volvo	₹1,600	₹1,800	
Taxis: Shimla–Mashobra–Shali Tibba–Narkanda, Hatu/Thanedar day	₹1,850	₹1,850	≈ ₹7.4k ÷ 4
Taxi Narkanda → Jibhi	₹1,750	₹2,375	Via Jalori vs via Mandi
Taxis Jibhi/Shoja day, Jibhi → Tirthan	₹975	₹975	
Taxi Tirthan → Naggar → Jana → Sethan, Sethan → Manali	₹1,675	₹1,675	
Metro, local buses	₹400	₹400	
Stays: Mashobra, Narkanda ×2, Jibhi ×2, Tirthan, Sethan (NYE)	₹6,200	₹7,700	Homestays, 2 per room
Food, 10 days	₹6,000	₹6,500	Homestay meals ₹300–400
Guide for Serolsar / entries	₹500	₹700	
Winter gear rentals	₹800	₹1,000	
Buffer	₹1,000	₹1,000	
TOTAL per person	**₹25,350**	**₹31,175**	**Slightly above ₹30k in 3A because of the private taxis. With 6 people in one Tempo Traveller the taxi share falls by about a third (≈ ₹29k).**

Bookings to do now

- Return train for 2 Jan (opened 3 Nov), then the onward train for 24 Dec (22691 Rajdhani first, then 12723).
- HRTC Volvo Delhi → Shimla (25 Dec) and Manali → Delhi (1 Jan).
- Homestays: Sethan for NYE (fills first), Jibhi (treehouses fill by mid-Dec), Narkanda. Most homestays take UPI advances and are flexible on dates.
- Save the Narkanda/Jibhi taxi number. One driver for Days 3–5 often gives a better package (~₹3,500–4,000 per day + ₹300 night halt).

Plan B

- Jalori closed and you don't want the 8–9 h detour: do the loop in reverse. Delhi → overnight Volvo to Aut → Jibhi/Tirthan first → Manali/Sethan → Kullu → Shimla–Narkanda at the end → Delhi.
- Heavy snow at Narkanda/Hatu: stay in Thanedar (lower) and do Hatu on foot only in clear weather.

- Sethan road closed by fresh snow: stay in Prini/Hampta village or Old Manali and walk up when it's cleared.

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** (Sikkim permits, J&K checks).
- Power bank (cold drains batteries 2× faster), offline Google Maps, cash ₹5–8k (ATMs fail in snow areas).
- Basic meds: Diamox (only after a doctor's advice) for Nathula / Chandrashila / Zuluk, paracetamol, ORS, cold & cough tabs, band-aids, Vaseline.
- Small daypack, reusable bottle, thermos (hot water in −5 °C mornings), quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear.
- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K do not work in Kashmir. Carry at least one **postpaid** connection (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Snow and roads change by the hour. Check HP/J&K/Sikkim/Uttarakhand police traffic updates and ask your homestay every evening. National emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- Do not ride rented two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice (Solang–Atal Tunnel, Narkanda, Gulmarg road, Chopta). Taxis with snow chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book stays for 24 Dec–1 Jan **in advance** (NYE rates in Manali/Shimla/Gulmarg/Darjeeling go 2–3× normal). Prefer free-cancellation rates.
- Keep 3 Jan as a pure buffer: plan to start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/airport) by 1 Jan, because snow and NYE traffic delay buses 3–8 h.

Sources checked

Reddit could not be searched from this environment (blocked), so traveller reports came from Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live fares could not be fetched (IRCTC needs login and captcha). Use the checklists above to verify.

— Jalori Pass seasonal closure and Jibhi access: vargiskhan.com Jalori guide, travelcoffee.in, The Tribune (NH-305 snow closures), Team-BHP 'Quiet flows Tirthan' travelogue
— Jibhi/Shoja/Tirthan winter conditions: tourmyholiday 2025 winter guide, travelcoffee.in 'Jibhi in December', Asianet Newsable winter guide
— Narkanda as a quiet snow alternative: indianholiday.com December guide, viacation.com
— Delhi–Aut bus and local Jibhi links: trekgo 'Jibhi by public bus', ixigo/abhibus Delhi–Aut listings
— Jibhi homestay rate ranges: Booking.com/Hotels.com Jibhi listings (Nov 2026 snapshots)
— Trains, HRTC and flights: same sources as the Overview PDF